

6.9 Difference between Prototype and MVP

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CS XII

Chapter 6: Entrepreneurship in the Digital Age

Lecture 10 of 16

6.9 Difference between Prototype and MVP

LEARN IT

Prototype and MVP are **related, but not the same**. A **prototype** is mainly used to **show and test the design** of an idea. An **MVP** is used to **test real use and market demand**. *Market demand* means whether enough people want the product and will use (or pay for) it.

Usually a prototype comes first and an MVP comes after it: Problem → Idea → Prototype → Feedback → MVP.

Table 6.6: Prototype and MVP comparison

Point	Prototype	MVP
Main purpose	To show how the idea may look or work.	To test whether users will actually use the solution.
Working status	May not work; can be a sketch or model.	Must work at least in a basic way.
Users	Small group gives feedback on design.	Early real users test the product in daily life.
Cost	Very low cost.	Low cost but may need some basic development.
Example	Paper screens for a canteen order system.	Google Form used for real canteen orders for three days.

REMEMBER IT

Key takeaway

Prototype = "Does it **look right** and make sense?"

MVP = "Will people **actually use it** and find value in it?"

Memory hook: **Prototype** → **P**icture of the idea; **MVP** → **M**arket test of the idea.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example: classify each item. Decide whether each is a prototype or an MVP and give the reason.

1. Hand-drawn screens of a tuition-finder app shown to 6 friends. → **Prototype**: it does not work; it tests design.
2. A WhatsApp broadcast group that really sends van arrival times to parents of one route for a week. → **MVP**: it works and real users use it daily.
3. Clickable PowerPoint screens of a notes organizer. → **Prototype** (mid-fidelity): links work, but nobody uses it for real notes.
4. A shared Google Drive folder per subject that a class actually uses before the monthly test. → **MVP**: real use in daily life.

Rule used: **Does it work, and is it used by real users in real life?** If yes → MVP. If it only shows the design → prototype.

COMMON MISTAKE

Mistake: Thinking "high-fidelity prototype" and "MVP" are the same because both look good.

Fix: The difference is **purpose and real use**, not appearance. A beautiful Figma design that nobody uses for real orders is still a prototype; a plain Google Form taking real orders is an MVP.

اردو میں سمجھیں

پروٹوٹائپ اور ایم وی پی آپس میں جڑے ہیں مگر ایک جیسے نہیں۔ پروٹوٹائپ خیال کا ڈیزائن دکھاتا اور آزماتا ہے اور ضروری نہیں کہ کام کرے، جبکہ ایم وی پی کم از کم بنیادی طور پر کام کرتا ہے اور اصل صارفین روزمرہ زندگی میں اسے استعمال کرتے ہیں۔ پروٹوٹائپ پوچھتا ہے "کیا یہ ٹھیک لگتا ہے؟" اور ایم وی پی پوچھتا ہے "کیا لوگ واقعی اسے استعمال کریں گے؟"

CHECK YOURSELF

1. Which one must work at least in a basic way?
2. Give the source's example of a prototype and of an MVP for the canteen.
3. Which question does a prototype answer?

Answers: 1. The MVP. 2. Prototype: paper screens for a canteen order system. MVP: a Google Form used for real canteen orders for three days. 3. "Does it look right and make sense?"

Extra board practice

These MCQs and questions are extra to the textbook. Close the notes, attempt them, then open the key.

MCQ 1. A prototype mainly:

- a. Shows/tests the design
- b. Takes real payments at scale always
- c. Replaces the company
- d. Is the beachhead

MCQ 2. An MVP mainly:

- a. Delivers the core working offer to real users to learn
- b. Is always paper
- c. Is always high-fi Figma only
- d. Has every feature

MCQ 3. You can have a prototype that is:

- a. Not working software
- b. Already the full product
- c. A DBMS
- d. An OSI stack

MCQ 4. You should not call a clickable mock the:

- a. MVP (if nobody can actually complete the job)
- b. Prototype
- c. Wireframe
- d. Test

MCQ 5. Order often is:

- a. Need → prototype → MVP → later product
- b. MVP → ignore users → prototype
- c. IPO → problem
- d. GPU → problem

MCQ 6. Exam 5-mark: table of:

- a. Purpose, working?, users, fidelity, example
- b. Only definitions swapped
- c. Only careers
- d. Only Python

Extra short questions

1. Four differences prototype vs MVP.
2. Can an MVP look ugly?
3. Can a prototype be digital?
4. One sentence you should memorise.

Extra long question

1. Table + one paragraph: for the canteen idea, what is the prototype and what is the MVP. Do not mix them.

Extra answer key

MCQs: 1. A 2. A 3. A 4. A 5. A 6. A

Short

1. Purpose design vs learning from a real offer; may not work vs must work; testers vs customers; cheap fake vs minimum real.
2. Yes — viability $\neq$ beauty.
3. Yes (Figma) — still not MVP if it doesn't deliver the job.
4. Prototype answers "do they understand it?"; MVP answers "do they use it?".

Long

1. Prototype: paper/Figma order flow. MVP: form that cooks actually receive and food is collected. Learning: % of orders picked up.

Next lecture: 6.10 Identifying the Riskiest Assumption